
The Morning: The Super Bowl

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The New York Times The Morning

February 6, 2026



By Sam Sifton

Good morning. Iranian and U.S. officials [are meeting in Oman](#). It's the first in-person negotiation since the United States and Iran were at war last June.

And the Olympics [open today in Italy](#). The Games are a show of global unity — in a moment when that seems very far away. The first medals will come tomorrow, but athletes are already curling, skating and skiing. [Follow along here](#).

But before we get to more news, let's huddle up.



Kirby Lee/Imagn Images, via Imagn Images Via Reuters Connect

America's game

The Super Bowl is one of our great secular holidays, rivaled only by Thanksgiving for its place in the American imagination. More than 125 million people watched the game last year, either for the contest itself or for the halftime show and the advertising that breaks up the plays and quarters.

Who's playing? It's the Seattle Seahawks and the New England Patriots this year, not that a majority of the viewers are likely to care. (The Seahawks are favored to win, at least according to the giant digital billboard for a prediction-market site that's outside my window in Times Square.) They just enjoy the spectacle, the wonder of a shared national experience, the thrill of not knowing what's going to happen.

Because anything can happen! In 2008, the New York Giants managed to squeak past the Patriots to win Super Bowl XLII, ruining their perfect season. Four years earlier, Justin Timberlake tore off a part of Janet Jackson's costume during the halftime show, introducing the term "wardrobe malfunction" to the world. And remember Katy Perry's Left Shark?

The Super Bowl's always magnetic, even if the peer-reviewed studies suggest the sport is not just dangerous but deadly.

The ads



George Clooney pitches Grubhub in one of two Super Bowl ads directed by Yorgos Lanthimos.

But maybe you're in it for the advertising, the chance to make like a client at Don Draper's shop, giving thumbs up or down to pitches from the creative teams. Mike Hale, one of our television critics, takes measure of the Super Bowl ads every year, updating his ratings as the commercials arrive on our screens. (He's tough. Clydesdales don't move him at all.)

Thus far, Mike's positive on Emma Stone for Squarespace (a collaboration with the arty director Yorgos Lanthimos) and the Christian ad campaign "He Gets Us." He's less so on Adrien Brody for TurboTax — and the N.F.L. tight ends who gathered to suggest that getting screened for prostate cancer allows a man to relax ... his tight end. ([See Mike's rankings here.](#))

Halftime!



Bad Bunny Godofredo A. Vázquez/Associated Press

Bad Bunny, fresh off his win for album of the year at last weekend's Grammy Awards, is the headliner. An American citizen from Puerto Rico, he sings and raps primarily in Spanish. How you feel about that probably says something about your politics.

It's not just the Spanish. The rapper and singer decried the Trump administration's immigration crackdown during the awards ceremony, angering many on the right. (President Trump called Bad Bunny a "terrible choice" for the halftime show and said he would not attend the game.) So however joyous his singing and dancing, his performance on Sunday will undoubtedly be, as my colleague Jennifer Medina put it, *con política*.

To counter it, the conservative group Turning Point USA announced that it would stream an alternative halftime show, headlined by Kid Rock. "We plan to play great songs for folks who love America," he said.

But a whole lot of people are looking forward to Bad Bunny — not least the small community of Puerto Ricans who have played professional football. "The stage is bigger than the N.F.L. itself," the retired offensive lineman Willie Colón [told The Times](#). "The stage is indicative to where we're at right now."

The feast



Mark Weinberg for The New York Times

Whatever you're watching at halftime, whatever team you're rooting for before and after it, whatever ads you like or loathe, there's no point in taking part in the Super Bowl game day on an empty stomach.

The gang I used to run with at NYT Cooking has plenty of [recipes for the day](#). But I'll give you my menu and see if it sparks joy: [oven-fried hot wings](#) with [blue cheese dressing](#); [cheese enchiladas](#); a honking big platter of [nachos](#); some [crab and artichoke dip](#).

The point, for me, is not so much to consume all that food as to make it for those who've come into my home to sit on the couch and watch the big screen. You don't want them dourly munching on a bag of chips. You want them laughing and prop-betting and discussing all that's happening around them, good and bad. Feed everyone heartily, and watch the human connection flourish. That's a good goal for all Americans this weekend, however you feel about the state of the world. See you on Sunday.



THE LATEST NEWS

Iran

Iran is [at work on its missile and nuclear sites](#), satellite images show. Several ballistic missile facilities were damaged in strikes last year.

The country's weapons program will likely be the subject of talks between the U.S. and Iran today.

Immigration

Many immigrants arrested in Minnesota are being sent to a [desolate detention camp](#) in West Texas, and then forced to find their own way home.

Senate Democrats are demanding major changes to ICE operations, and Republicans are digging in against them. Lawmakers [left Washington for the weekend](#) without making progress.

Politics



The Trump administration finalized a new policy to [strip job protections from up to 50,000 federal workers](#). It makes it easier for Trump to remove or discipline them — going beyond the roughly 4,000 political appointees the president generally controls.

Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. asserted that the [keto diet could cure schizophrenia](#). Experts say the claim is unfounded.

Russia-Ukraine War

Russia, Ukraine and the U.S. ended the [latest round of peace talks](#) without making much progress toward ending the war.

Elon Musk's satellite service, Starlink, [blocked Russian troops' internet access](#) at Ukraine's request. Russian military bloggers said troops were experiencing internet outages that hampered frontline communications.

The last major nuclear treaty between the U.S. and Russia has expired. In the video below, David Sanger, a national security correspondent, explains how we got here. Click to watch.



The New York Times

Business and Economy

Argentina and the U.S. [signed a sweeping trade deal](#).

Mark Carney, Canada's prime minister, wants to turn the country into a leader in electric vehicles. He proposed [billions of dollars in incentives and tax breaks](#) to make that happen.

Bitcoin [dropped sharply](#) in the past week. It's now worth about half of what it was in October, at its peak.

A jury in Phoenix ordered Uber to [pay \\$8.5 million](#) to a woman who said one of its drivers had raped her. There are thousands of similar cases around the U.S.

International



The crown of Empress Eugénie. Thomas Clot/Musée du Louvre

The Louvre thieves dropped a priceless crown. [See what it once looked like.](#)

In Japan, a pregnant parliamentary candidate is upending an election and [challenging gender expectations in the country.](#)

OPINIONS

Canadians have been mad at America for a while. As Trump's threatens territorial expansion, [that rage is spreading across the West](#), writes **Stephen Marche**.

Carlos Lozada [wrote an elegy](#) for The Washington Post he loved.

Introducing Crossplay

Go word to word in our first 2-player game. Spell. Score. Outsmart your opponent. [Download app](#)

MORNING READS



Brock McGillis and Matthew Ward. Steph Martyniuk for The New York Times

Heated? Yes. Rivalry? No: A gay former professional hockey player married a sales associate at Cartier in Toronto after a decade of ups and downs. [Click!](#)

A tea party: A playtime experiment showed scientists that apes [have the capacity for make-believe](#).

Your pick: The most-clicked story in The Morning yesterday was [about Swedish lighting](#).



TODAY'S NUMBER

1×10^{-12}

— That is one-trillionth. [Laboratories that conduct sports doping tests](#) have instruments that can detect substances down to that fraction of a gram, known as a picogram.

WINTER OLYMPICS



Jessie Diggins of the U.S. training for cross-country skiing. Kai Pfaffenbach/Reuters

[Sign up to our Games Briefing](#) to follow the latest from the Olympics, which will run for the next few weeks.

The opening ceremony for the Milan-Cortina Games is today. The Times [spoke with the man who designed it](#).

Safety: Guarding the Games is one of the largest security operations in Italian history, involving 6,000 security personnel, robots and [surveillance drones](#).

Cross-country skiing: Jessie Diggins is the best-ever American in the sport. The Times Magazine [explains how she trains her body](#).

Snowboarding: The American star Red Gerard failed to qualify for the Big Air finals. He blamed a [wonky rule](#).

Women's Hockey: The match between Canada and Finland was postponed a week after a [norovirus outbreak](#) hit Finland's roster. Meanwhile, the United States opened with a [5-1 win](#) over the Czech Republic.

CATHY AND HEATHCLIFF ❤️



In “Wuthering Heights.” Warner Bros.

Did Emily Brontë write the greatest love story of all time? As a new film adaptation of “Wuthering Heights” comes to the screen, our critic A.O. Scott tries to answer the question by taking a close look at a handful of sentences in the 1847 novel. “No picture will ever quite match the book’s thousands of feverish, hungry, astonishing words,” he writes. [Read one intense passage.](#)

More on culture



In Agra, India. Saumya Khandelwal for The New York Times

In a new film, Bollywood has [embraced a Taj Mahal conspiracy theory](#).

A one-off episode in “Wonder Man,” the new Marvel series on Disney+, provides an intriguing alternative to the company’s usual fare of goofy C.G.I. action sequences, [writes Maya Phillips](#), a Times culture critic: “The show’s pointedly meta, more adult sense of humor grounds the action in our world, our Hollywood, our celebrities.”

After nearly a century of airport, pharmacy and supermarket sales, the cheap mass market paperback is nearing extinction, [reports Elizabeth Harris](#), who covers the book industry. Sales have been on the decline for years as readers have turned to the larger format known as trade paperbacks, and to audiobooks and e-books.

Late night hosts joked about [Trump at the National Prayer Breakfast](#).



In “Bridgerton.” Netflix

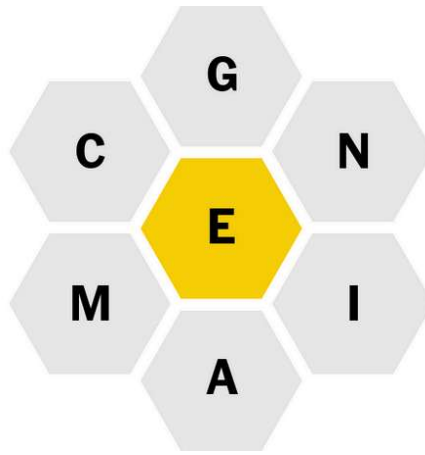
Watch “Bridgerton” tackle the orgasm gap. [Sex therapists are happy about it.](#)

Dry yourself after a shower with [this luxuriously soft and thick towel](#) recommended by the scrupulous bathroom attendants at Wirecutter.

Take [our news quiz.](#)



GAMES



Here is [today's Spelling Bee](#). Yesterday's pangram was *midmonth*.

And here are [today's Mini Crossword](#), [Wordle](#), [Connections](#), [Sports Connections](#) and [Strands](#).

***Thanks for spending part of your morning with The Times and me.
See you tomorrow. — Sam***

Reach our team at themorning@nytimes.com.



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